

The Labtec Arena 530 4.1 speaker performed well here too. There was minimal distortion at the maximum volume level. This means if you really like low frequency response, it would be a good idea to go in for this speaker system. However, one glaring disadvantage is that the Labtec Arena shudders quite a lot while playing low frequency sounds at considerably higher volume levels. Coming in a very close second was the Sumoku Alpha - 7—in spite of being a pseudo four-channel speaker system, this one exhibited very commendable power handling capabilities. The other speakers that performed well in playing back high frequencies at high volumes turned out to be the Artis 800 and the Artis 880. One of the speakers that was really battered in the ultimate bass test was the Typhoon 5D. It exhibited a very high amount of distortion and the overall sound quality was exceedingly noisy. The Logitech Soundman Xtrusio DSR 100 also performed poorly here as its sound quality fell drastically once the volume levels were raised beyond the 60 per cent mark.

The undisputed winner among the 5.1 speakers was once again the Artis X8. We expected an overall distorted sound but the X8 was able to hold its own and play both the ultimate bass test and the ultimate treble test file with minimum distortion. If you like playing songs and movies at the highest volumes possible, the Artis X8 should be your pick. On the other hand, the Typhoon Acoustic 5.1 was audibly stretched under the stress of the power-handling test. It generated a lot of distortion when playing at maximum volume levels—we could hardly hear any vocals while the sound file was being played at the maximum volume.

Warranty and support

In terms of the product warranty and service infrastructure,

Decision Maker				
You need	To play music and day-to-day work		Surround gaming and home theatre	
Look for	Stereo speakers that have a good frequency response, decent power and accessible volume controls		Support for at least four discrete channels (ideally 5.1), good transient response, separate inputs for front and rear channels (stay away from pseudo four-channel speakers), adequate power for reproducing movie audio effects like gunshots and explosions	
The models	Price-conscious	Performance	Price-conscious	Performance
	Typhoon DS1032, Mercury SW-980	Artis S320, Sumoku Alpha - 4R	Artis S880, Logitech Soundman Xtrusio DSR 100	Artis X8 5.1, Labtec Arena 530
Price range	Rs 800 to Rs 1,400	Rs 2,000 to Rs 2,200	Rs 4,000 to Rs 12,000	Rs 6,000 to Rs 12,000

there is a wide variation among the brands. The most comprehensive after-sales support and coverage is by Logitech, which has 25 service centres over the same number of cities. Coming in a close second is Creative with 18 service centres in the same number of cities and Labtec with 15 service centres in 15 cities.

The brands that are lacking in service support are Mercury, Artis, Typhoon and Sumoku. Mercury has just two service centres each in four cities. Though Artis has authorised dealerships in eight cities, it has authorised service centres in just two of these. Typhoon has service centres in seven cities, while Sumoku has only five.

What it all leads to

Sound for your computer has truly evolved over the past year, where it is now being given the importance it is due. In the face of applications that are more demanding on the audio performance of your PC such as MP3 audio and DVD, you will never really be satisfied with the plain-Jane stereo speakers. Let's take a look at the speakers that lived up to these new age applications.

Buying Tips

Power rating: Always go by the RMS power rating of a speaker system rather than the Peak Music Power Output (PMPO). RMS is the true technical measure of a speaker's capability to handle continuous power. For your computer-based surround speaker system, a rating of 40 watts RMS is a good place to start.

Frequency response: If your speaker system has a frequency range that is limited at the upper end (if it cannot perform above 16 KHz, for example), you will not hear any of the high trebles and will lose definition in your music, especially if you listen to a lot of classical music. Similarly, if your speaker system cannot go below 50 Hz, it will not be able to correctly reproduce the low frequencies such as bass drums and explosions in movies.

Stands: When buying 2.1 speakers primarily for music playback, you wouldn't need speaker stands as you would most probably place them directly on your desktop. However, for a 4.1 or 5.1 speaker system, ensure that each satellite has a base or a stand. This is useful for placing them behind you on a wall or even standing on the floor at ear-level for proper surround sound imaging.

Controls: Speakers with an in-line volume control give you the freedom to control the master speaker volume without having to reach troublesome locations like the subwoofer where the volume controls are generally placed.

Audio inputs: If you have a standard 2.1 stereo speaker system, you only need standard analogue left and right channels. However, in the case of a four-point surround sound system, look out for four separate channels of analogue audio inputs to your speaker system. This would be in the form of two 3.5 mm stereo inputs (left/right for front and left/right for rear) or four separate RCA inputs. Also watch out for pseudo four-channel speakers—these are basically just stereo speakers. In the case of 5.1 speakers, you would need either six separate RCA inputs for the discrete AC-3 channels (if the signal is already being decoded by an external decoder like the Sound Blaster Live! 5.1 DE soundcard) or a DIN connector that is fed by the digital output of your soundcard in order to have true Dolby Digital compliance.

